

01

THE THREE QUESTIONS EVERY PROOF MUST SURVIVE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ Do not treat "proof" univocally: demonstration, probable inference and practical postulate have different success conditions. □□ Do not say the ontological argument is a posteriori because Anselm "observes" that people have the idea of God — the premise is conceptual. □□ Do not equate "a priori" with "certain" and "a posteriori" with "uncertain"; a priori reasoning can be invalid, and a posteriori reasoning can be strong. □□ Distinguish validity from soundness from adequacy of the God established.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Do not treat "proof" univocally: demonstration, probable inference and practical postulate have different success conditions. □□ Do not say the ontological argument is a posteriori because Anselm "observes" that people have the idea of God — the premise is conceptual. □□ Do not equate "a priori" with "certain" and "a posteriori" with "uncertain"; a priori reasoning can be invalid, and a posteriori reasoning can be strong. □□ Distinguish validity from soundness from adequacy of the God established.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The a priori proof promises necessity but is charged with the existence-predicate fallacy.

ANSWER LINE: Every proof must be tested for validity, soundness and adequacy: whether the conclusion follows, the premises are true and the being reached is genuinely God.

02

THE ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT AS A REDUCTIO

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ Distinction to state in the answer: Anselm argues by reductio from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from essence containment ("existence is a perfection").

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ Distinction to state in the answer: Anselm argues by reductio from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from essence containment ("existence is a perfection").

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It is the argument that has attracted the most sustained modern logical attention of all the proofs. □□ Do not manufacture an "Indian ontological argument" out of Advaita.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Gaunilo offers a parody (the form proves too much); Kant offers a diagnosis (the form uses "existence" illegitimately). □□ Do not attribute the island example to Kant, or the thaler example to Gaunilo. □□ Descartes' ontological proof (Meditations V) must not be confused with his causal proof from the idea of the infinite (Meditations III). □□ The modal version does not defeat Kant "cleanly"; it relocates the problem to the possibility premise. □□ Do not say the ontological argument is "obviously absurd".

ANSWER LINE: The ontological argument is an a priori attempt to derive God's necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable being.

03

TWO KINDS OF CAUSAL SERIES (THE WHOLE ARGUMENT TURNS ON THIS)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ Kant's objection, spelled out because it is frequently mis-stated: the cosmological argument concludes to a necessary being; but to move from "a necessary being" to "the most real being (ens realissimum), i.e.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

They start from different features and terminate in differently described conclusions. □□ "First" means explanatory priority, not chronological firstness. □□ Aquinas does not argue that the universe began in time; he holds that its beginning is known by faith. □□ The Kalam does argue for a temporal beginning; it is not Aquinas' argument. □□ Do not attribute Paley's watch to Aquinas (see Subtopic 4). □□ Kant's objection is that the cosmological argument borrows the ontological argument, not that it is invalid on its own terms. □□ Way 3 is modal (contingency/necessity); Way 2 is causal.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Kant's objection, spelled out because it is frequently mis-stated: the cosmological argument concludes to a necessary being; but to move from "a necessary being" to "the most real being (ens realissimum), i.e.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Keep them apart. □□ Do not say Hume "refuted" the cosmological argument; he attacked the necessity of the regress-stop and the identification of the cause with God.

ANSWER LINE: □□ Ways 1–3 constitute the cosmological family; Way 4 is the henological / degrees argument; Way 5 is the teleological one, treated in Subtopic 4.

04

THREE TELEOLOGIES THAT MUST NOT BE CONFUSED

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Three Teleologies That Must Not Be Confused is analysed by relating Why the difference matters to watch, then testing the relationship through never seen a watch made and does not always work perfectly.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

That chronological point is a genuine fact worth stating, because it forestalls the naive assumption that Hume was replying to Paley.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ □ The trap: Hume does not claim to prove that no designer exists.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ But the decisive difference: Western theists generally believe God is not only the cause of the unity/order of things but also the creative energy that gives existence to the things of Nature.

ANSWER LINE: □ The inference is not weakened if I have never seen a watch made (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence. □ The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism does not always work perfectly — as may appear to be the case with the mechanism of the world. □ The inference is not undermined if there are parts whose function we cannot discover — as there are in nature.

05

KANT'S TWO-STOREY STRUCTURE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Kant'S Two-Storey Structure is analysed by relating logical inference to Newman's version, then testing the relationship through Hick's objection and sovereign claim.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs and the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that the basic assumption of all such arguments is that moral values are not capable...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

This is the topic's most penalised error. □□ Three postulates — freedom, immortality, God — not one. □□ Newman's conscience argument is not Kant's; keep the two forms separate. □□ God is not the source of moral obligation for Kant; the moral law is autonomous. □□ Euthyphro refutes divine-command theories, not Kant's postulate. □□ "Ought implies can" applies to promoting the highest good, not to achieving it single-handedly. □□ Do not present the postulate as a reward-motive; that would be heteronomy and would destroy moral worth on Kant's own terms. □□ Do not omit the Indian comparison; karmaphaladātā is the natural Indian counterpart.

ANSWER LINE: □ Hick's objection: the basic assumption of all such arguments is that moral values are not capable of naturalistic explanation — in terms of human needs, desires, ideals, self-interest, or the structure of human nature or society.

06

NYĀYA'S COSMIC DIVISION OF LABOUR

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

God is creator, preserver and destroyer — hence theism, not deism.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Atoms are the eternal material causes. □□ Nyāya theism is theism, not deism — God preserves and destroys as well as creates. □□ Eternal intelligence is an inseparable attribute of God in Nyāya, not His essence as in Advaita. □□ Do not answer "the nature of Nyāya's God" merely by listing Udayana's proofs, or vice versa. □□ Adṛṣṭa does not consciously distribute its own fruits — that unconsciousness is the whole premise of the argument. □□ Enumerations of the proofs vary; say so and use the ones the question needs. □□ The Veda–God circularity is answered by the order-of-existence / order-of-knowledge distinction; do not concede the circle. □□ Do not treat Nyāya as "the Indian Aquinas" without flagging the material-causation divergence.

ANSWER LINE: Nyāya's Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient, omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.

07

TWO COMPLETELY DIFFERENT SENSES OF "GOD" IN THE INDIAN DEBATE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

UPSC's 2019 wording presupposes that Jainism has something to prove; the mature answer explains which sense of "God" Jainism proves and which it refutes.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects...

ANSWER LINE: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

08

PART I — JAINISM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

In that Vedic sense Jainism and Buddhism are nāstika; but they are intensely spiritual and ethical, and denial of God does not amount to atheism in the Western sense — otherwise Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which likewise do not believe in a creator God, could not have been counted orthodox.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Jainism is "a religion without God" in the sense of a creator. □ There is no necessity of bringing in God to explain creation, for the world was never created: production, destruction and permanence characterise all substances; things have creation and dissolution because of their modes (pariāya), while the substances themselves are eternal.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ "Though Jainism denies God, it does not deny godhead.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

In that Vedic sense Jainism and Buddhism are nāstika; but they are intensely spiritual and ethical, and denial of God does not amount to atheism in the Western sense — otherwise Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which likewise do not believe in a creator God, could not have been counted orthodox.

ANSWER LINE: Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

09

PART II — BUDDHISM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change. □ If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness. □ The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. □ Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change. □ If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness. □ The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. □ Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

If God determines all, karma and moral effort are meaningless; if God does not determine all, God is not the sufficient cause and the theistic explanation is redundant. □□ The Dharmakīrti / Śāntarākṣita line.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Philosophical force, stated correctly: the Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus.

ANSWER LINE: Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

10

PART III — MĪMĀṂSĀ

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ And the direct counter to Nyāya's adṛṣṭa proof: apūrva is the unseen potency produced by correctly performed ritual; it persists after the act and matures into future fruit.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ And the direct counter to Nyāya's adṛṣṭa proof: apūrva is the unseen potency produced by correctly performed ritual; it persists after the act and matures into future fruit.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Prabhākara adds niyoga: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one ought to act because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answering the 2019 question with "Jainism is atheistic" misreads it. □□ Jaina godhood is plural, achieved and non-creative; a śiddha has no cosmic function. □□ Jaina karma is material (puḍgala); do not equate it with Nyāya's adṛṣṭa or a generic moral force. □□ Nāstika means denier of Vedic authority, not denier of spirit. □□ Buddhism's critique is a refusal of explanatory surplus, not a proof of atheism. □□ The ayākṛta silence is a methodological judgement, not agnostic evasion. □□ Mīmāṃsā's Veda is authorless — not God-authored; this is the exact contradictory of Nyāya's third proof. □□ Apūrva is Mīmāṃsā's substitute for a fruit-dispensing God; do not call it "karma" loosely. □□ Do not say Sāṃkhya "has no view"; classical Sāṃkhya is nirīśvara and also denies a creator. □□ Do not present these schools as a single "Indian atheism".

ANSWER LINE: Mīmāṃsā (school of inquiry into ritual duty) treats the Veda (sacred revealed knowledge) as authorless and karma (morally consequential action) as self-fructifying, thereby displacing the need for God.